defences and pushing forward with a mobile column to clear the road to Dirang Dzong. What happened afterwards, who ran where, is of little consequence.

We have seen how, on a visit to 2 Rajput in 1959, as the battalion prepared to move to Walong, Thimayya had told the officers assembled in the mess that he hoped they wouldn't be cannon fodder for the Chinese when and if the attack came. At the two extremities of the Indo-Tibet border, if the men felt they were just that, they could be forgiven. 6 Kumaon, having taken over the defence of Walong from 2 Rajput, were abruptly ordered to move to Kibithu which was a screening position held by the Assam Rifles. After the Chinese attacked on 20 October they were ordered to fall back on Walong.

Here, too, a young lieutenant was to distinguish himself, for while falling back, 6 Kumaon's action on the nullah near Ashi Hill halted the Chinese advance for a few days. Lieutenant Bikram Singh was never given his due by way of a gallantry award, despite having distinguished himself yet again in the actual battle of Walong where he was eventually killed. Lieutenant Colonel Madiah, on his return from China where he was a POW, was categorical in saying that Bikram Singh was the one true hero in Walong. It is perhaps fitting, that among those who know of Walong, he is known as the Lion of the Namti Valley.

How ironical that in the Ladakh Sector, the handful of men deployed in penny packets in some of the most inhospitable terrain in the world, flying the flag at DBO, Qara Qash, Galwan and Srijap should put up such a gallant fight when commanders with entire brigades at their disposal should be found wanting in other sectors.

When the final phase of the fighting began on 18 November, despite the stoic resistance of the Kumaonis and the Gorkhas at Rezang-la and Gurung Hill respectively, 114 Brigade capitulated on 19 November, thereby abandoning the Chushul airfield and the entire line of defence on the Rezang Ridge. What saved India from major embarrassment in the Western Sector was the fact that the Chinese did not stay in contact with the retreating Indian troops as had been the case in NEFA. Here too, there was no pre-planned second line of defence, and at the end of the day, the fact is that a retreating army is a defeated army.

So what went wrong in Ladakh? Brigadier Raina had twenty-five days to reorganize himself after Brigade HQ had helplessly watched Dhan Singh